



THE BRAND-FUNDED DOCUMENTARY SYSTEM

MODULE 3

Building the 25-Brand Target List

Practical funding strategy for independent and documentary filmmakers

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Positioning told you what you're selling and to whom. This module turns "to whom" into a real list of 25 companies with real names and a real human to email at each one. This is the list your entire outreach campaign runs on. Build it carefully; a sloppy or lazy, not well thought through list wastes every email that follows.

You'll use a companion asset here: **the Brand Category Target Map**, a separate file with 60+ brand categories, each scored for fit against ten documentary genres, with a note on why each category funds docs and where to find the entry point. Keep it open beside your workbook.

The process

Four steps. Do them in order.

Step 1, Circle your fit categories

Open the Brand Category Target Map. The fit key is simple: **++ = natural fit, + = workable, ○ = stretch**. From your Module 2 worksheet, your genre and your two lead assets, circle every category scoring **++** for your genre.

Don't reach for the **+** and **○** categories yet. Start with the natural fits. You'll usually find more **++** categories than you can pursue, which is a good problem.

Step 2, Three companies per category, in three tiers

For each circled category, name **three real companies across three tiers**:

- **National leader**: the biggest name in the category.
- **Challenger brand**: the ambitious #2, #3, or #4 trying to take share.
- **Regional player**: a local or regional company in your film's geography.

Here's the rule that surprises people: **challenger and regional brands close faster and answer their own email**. The national leader has a wall of agencies, a booked calendar, and a hundred filmmakers already asking. The challenger is hungry for exactly the kind

of values-and-audience story your film offers, and the regional player might have the marketing director answer the phone herself.

So weight your list accordingly. **Target mix for the 25: about 5 nationals, about 10 challengers, about 10 regional/local.** Most of your real conversations will come from the bottom two tiers. Plan for it.

Step 3 , Disqualify ruthlessly

Cut any brand that trips these wires:

- **In active PR (public relations) crisis on your film's topic.** (Exception: if your film is genuinely their redemption arc, that's an advanced play, handle with care.)
- **Values conflict with your subjects' dignity.** If the brand's business undercuts the people in your film, it's out.
- **Your subjects would object.** This is the hard line: **your subjects' trust is non-negotiable, and it is also your product.** A sponsorship that betrays the people who let you into their lives destroys the exact thing the sponsor is paying for. When in doubt, protect the subjects. Always.

Step 4 , The one-sentence fit test

For each of the 25 survivors, write ONE sentence in this shape:

"[Brand] should fund [film] because [asset #] gives them [specific outcome]."

If you can't write that sentence, clearly, specifically, without handwaving, **cut the brand.** A brand you can't make the case for is a brand you'll fumble on the call. The sentence is your filter. If it's mushy, the fit is mushy.

By the end of Step 4 you have 25 brands, each with a named tier and a one-sentence reason. That's the target list.

Finding the human (not info@)

A perfect list emailed to `info@` is a list emailed to a trash folder. You need a person. Hunt these titles, in this order:

- 1 **Brand / Content / Partnerships Manager**

- 2 **CMO (chief marketing officer)** (at smaller companies, this is often the right door)
- 3 **Sponsorship Manager**
- 4 **Corporate Communications**
- 5 **The agency of record's content lead**

LinkedIn search string:

`"[brand]" AND (brand OR content OR partnerships) AND (manager OR director) `

For regional brands: just call. Ask for marketing. A regional company will often tell you the name and connect you. This is faster than any LinkedIn spelunking and it's why regional brands are worth so much of your list.

The example thread continues

Dana (fictional; illustrative) opens the Target Map with her genre; Health, and her two lead assets, audience access and values proof.

She circles the ++ Health-fit categories: regional health insurers (#3), hospital systems (#4), workwear brands (#31, scrubs and nursing workwear), senior living and care (#27), mental-health platforms (#26), and universities and colleges (#19, nursing programs). A rich field.

She builds three companies per category across tiers. For workwear: a national scrubs leader, a challenger scrubs brand growing fast, and a regional uniform supplier. For insurers: a national carrier, a regional health plan, and a rural-lines specialist. She weights toward challenger and regional, landing near the 5/10/10 mix.

She disqualifies two: a national insurer with a live PR problem over rural clinic closures (a wound her film touches, out), and a brand her nurse subjects had privately criticized (subjects' trust is non-negotiable, out).

Then the one-sentence test. Easy one: *"[Regional health plan] should fund the film because audience access puts its brand in front of exactly the rural nurses and communities it insures, proving its member-first values better than any ad."* Clean. Keep. A harder one she couldn't finish without hedging, a national appliance brand she'd added on a whim, she cut.

For the humans: on the challenger scrubs brand she found a Brand Partnerships Manager on LinkedIn with the search string. On the regional health plan she called the main line, asked for marketing, and got the marketing director's name in ninety seconds.

She ends with 25 brands, tiered, each with a real human and a one-sentence reason.

Common mistakes

- **All-national lists.** The most impressive names are the least reachable. If your 25 skews national, you built a list that won't answer.
- **Emailing `info@`.** No human, no reply. Find the person or call.
- **Skipping the disqualification pass** to keep the list at 25. A brand that betrays your subjects isn't a target; it's a liability. Cut it and find another.
- **Keeping brands, you can't write the sentence for.** The one-sentence test is not optional. If it's mushy, the brand is out.
- **Three companies that are all the same tiers.** The whole point is the tier spread. One of each, every category.
- **Chasing the ++ and ○ categories before exhausting ++.** Natural fits first. Always.

Action checklist

- ☐ Circled every ++ category for your genre on the Brand Category Target Map.
- ☐ Named three real companies per circled category, national leader, challenger, regional player.
- ☐ Ran the disqualification pass: PR crisis, values conflict, subject objection. Cut what tripped a wire.
- ☐ Wrote the one-sentence fit test for each survivor; cut any brand you couldn't finish the sentence for.
- ☐ Trimmed to **25 brands** at roughly 5 national / 10 challenger / 10 regional.

- ☐ Found a named human at each brand (titles in order, LinkedIn string, or a phone call for regionals).
- ☐ Logged all 25 with tier, contact name, and one-sentence reason in your Sponsor-Fit Workbook.

With 25-tiered brands and a human at each, you're ready to build the pitch. Go to Module 4.